US Army Drone Team

Recruiting the Army's All-Star Team

Executive Summary

The US Army Drone Team recruited new talent from 15–29 October using the Velocidrone First Person View (FPV) simulator. Starting with over 120 applicants, the team analyzed letters of recommendation, Soldier Talent Profiles, and conducted interviews to select 20 new members. The mission: identify the Army's best FPV operators, train them to a common standard, and equip them with the newest drone technology to compete in national and international events while driving Army-wide innovation in small UAS and FPV operations.

Background

by CPT JACOB E BICKUS

The October recruitment drive began with distribution of the official flyer and QR code. Recognizing that some of the best candidates might not have Army-issued emails, the team developed a password-protected process to verify Soldier status and prevent unauthorized access. Applicants scanned the QR code to request entry to the US Army Drone Team SharePoint and public webpage at `https://usarmydroneteam.onrender.com`.

Soldiers without an Army email provided a sponsor's *army.mil* address to validate eligibility. Working with the National Drone Association, SSG Alwyne Smith designed a secure Velocidrone track for the competition. Once approved, Soldiers received the passcode to access the track and could practice freely until the 29 October submission deadline.

Results

Over 120 Soldiers applied to the team from the grades of E-2 to O-5. The average UAS experience of the applicants was 4–5 years, although most of the applicants were largely experienced in the retired RQ-7 Shadow. The logged race completion time spread was from 64–243 seconds. The average time for Soldiers selected as primary members of the team was 82.3 seconds. The applicants hailed from units across the globe including Hawaii, Germany, and nearly every major FORSCOM division (see Figure 1).

Lessons Learned

While this recruiting effort was an immense success, future efforts to recruit should incorporate the following marketing efforts:

- Integrating social media outreach
- Leveraging MILPER message announcements
- Using division and brigade executive officer channels

While Velocidrone offers unmatched realism, its licensing cost remains a barrier for some Soldiers. Potential solutions include:

- Identifying alternative free simulation software
- Requesting funds from 1st Aviation Brigade to subsidize licenses
- Authorizing Velocidrone distribution through the company portal

Looking Forward

The US Army Drone Team will host its next recruitment effort in April 2026. The team will double from 20 Soldiers to 40 Soldiers during "Phase II." In addition to competitive events, the team will collaborate with Combat Training Centers (CTCs) and the SERE School to support training operations. Applying lessons from Phase I, the team aims to strengthen Army-wide UAS innovation and achieve lasting drone dominance.

☎ 412-849-6898 ✉ jacob.e.bickus.mil@army.mil

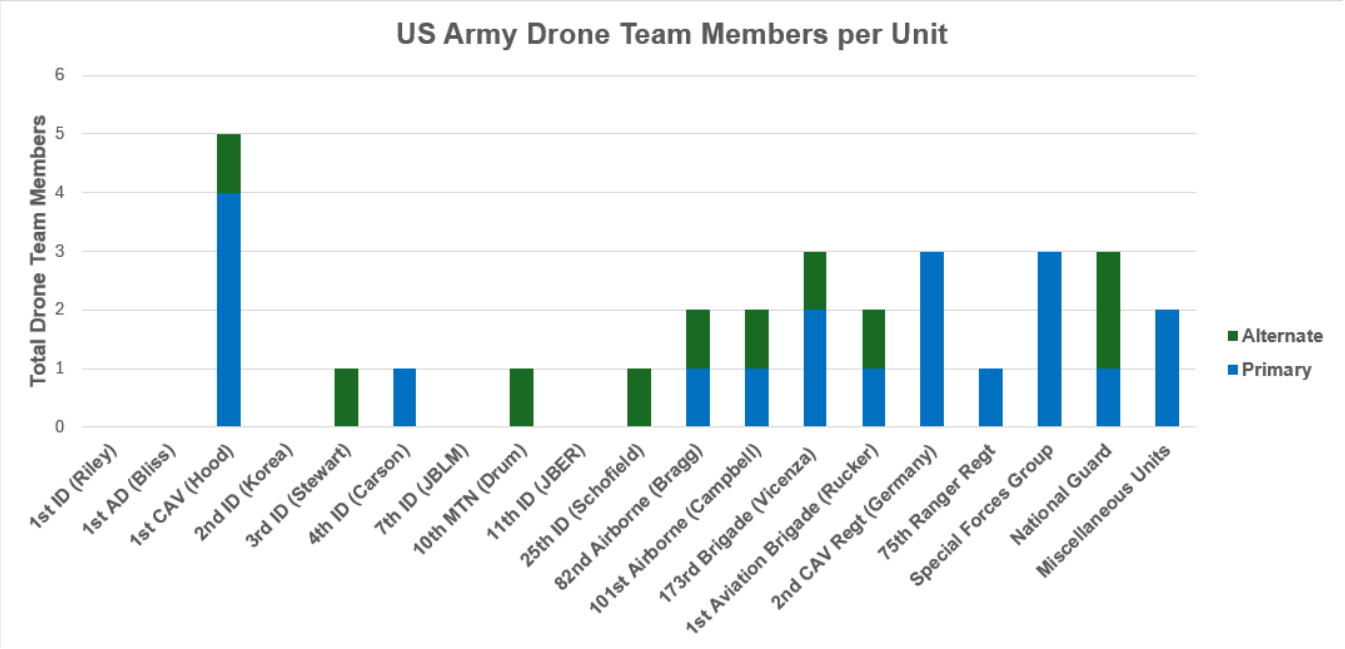


Figure 1: US Army Drone Team Members per Unit. Includes every major FORSCOM unit as well as SOCOM and National Guard. Miscellaneous units include the Artificial Intelligence Integration Center (AI2C) in Pennsylvania and the 780th Military Intelligence Brigade (Cyber) in Maryland. The total primary members was 20 and the total alternate members selected was 10.